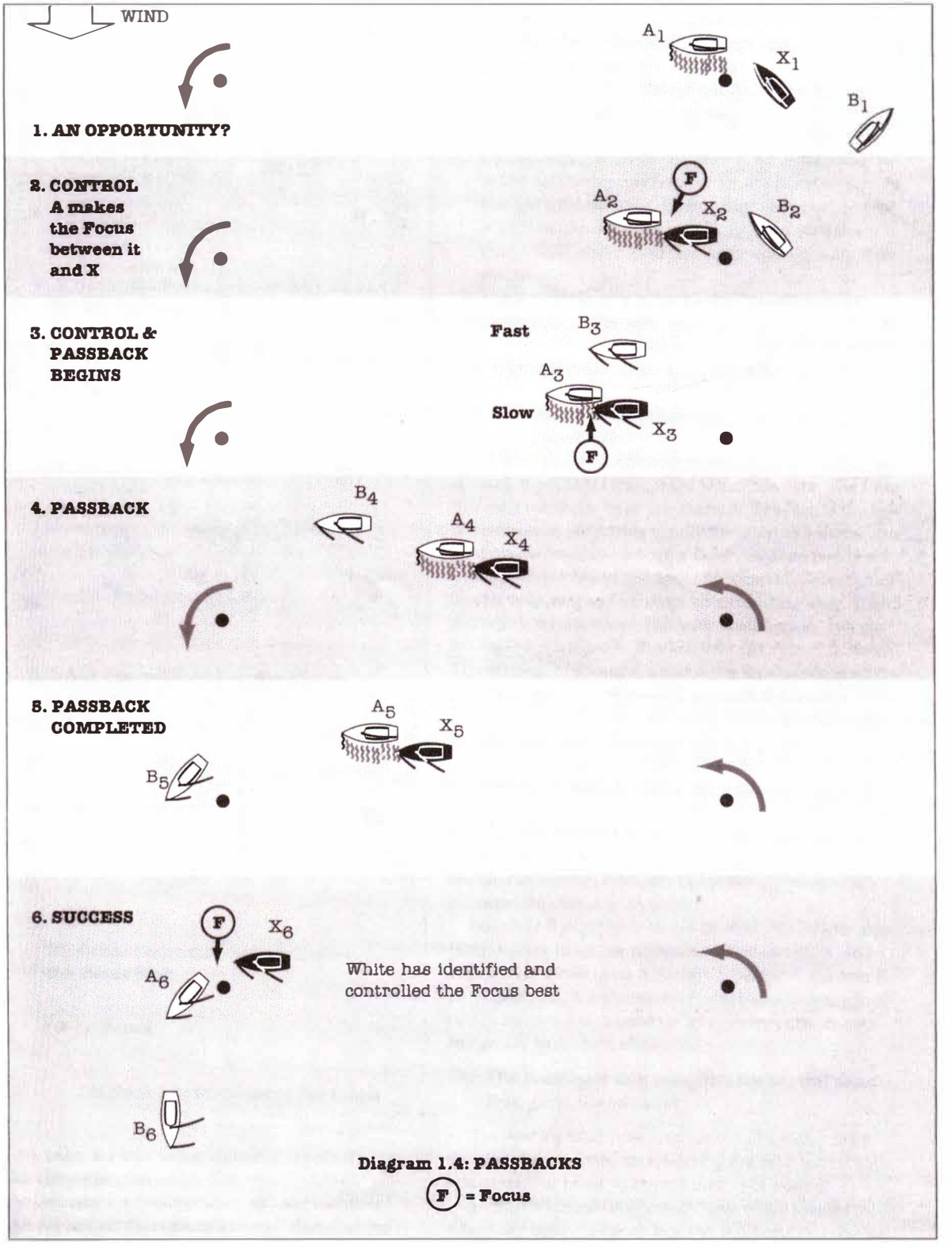


Diagram 1.4: PASSBACKS

(F) = Focus

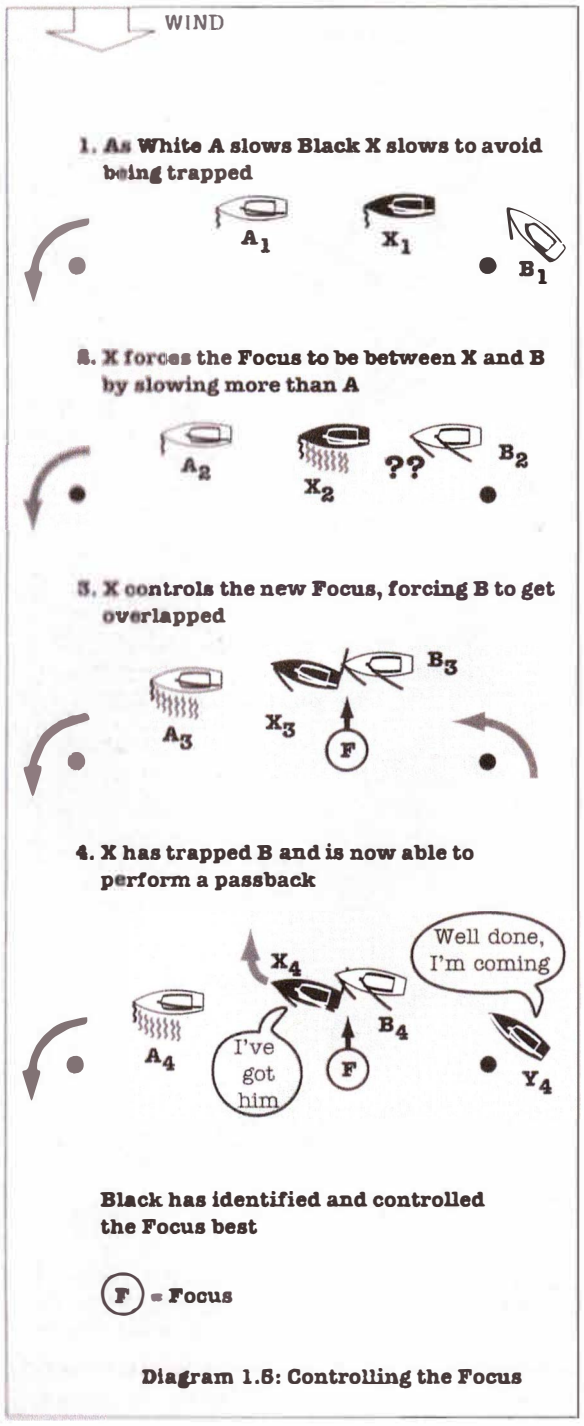


Diagram 1.5: Controlling the Focus

opposing boats are interlinked and what actions they are likely to carry out.

To understand the concept you will need to follow through the normal "overtaking pattern" that emerges when one team starts to manoeuvre against another. The stages I describe in reality often merge together but it will help if the components are understood.

A team race position change usually follows this pattern:

- One boat decides to **compress** the race by slowing the boat behind it.
- As the boats get closer together it becomes easier to see an overtaking opportunity for any boats astern. At this point the initiating, leading boat seeks to **control** what is happening, for example, by preventing the enemy boat astern from tacking or slowing them with windshadow.
- The **passback** now takes place. This refers to the moment when the team mate boat sails around the pair of boats and is therefore promoted two places while the opposition boat loses one place (Diagram 1.4).

1.5.3 Summary: Compress → Control → Passback

The F with a circle around it has been used in the diagrams to mark the **CONTROL FOCUS** of the race. The focus may be a particular boat (for example X) which is the key component in converting the combination to a better one or it may be used to refer to a **GAP** between two boats over which the teams will battle for control. Control may involve **trapping** and **slowing**, or **extending** away. Which you try to do will depend on your combination. The gap in Diagram 1.5 is just such a focus for the race in question. This concept of a focus is a useful one for identifying where the action needs to happen. This means the team is more likely to know what they are trying to achieve, because as you can see there is a need to **work together**.

In the run up to the COMPRESS manoeuvres described in Diagram 1.4, boat X will be trying to get closer to B by "trapping" her in 3rd place so she is unable to do the overtake required to make the 1st , 2nd combination. This effort by X will also bring the whole race back together so the overall distance from 6th to 1st will decrease, which increases the chance of an upset.

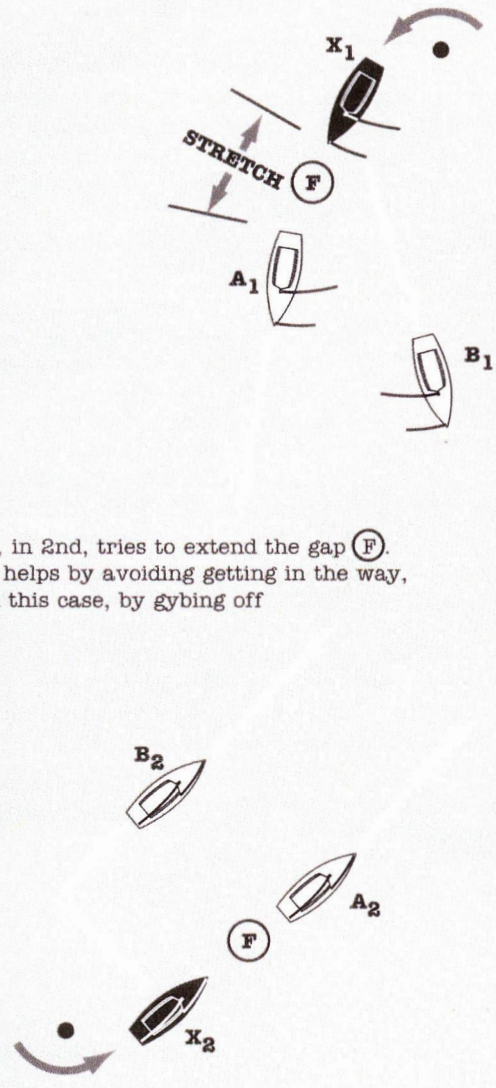
Naturally B might also realise that the FOCUS for this team is going to be the passback manoeuvre on X, so he stays back a bit allowing A to trap X before X can trap B. In Diagram 1.5, X controls the Focus best and traps B. In reality, success will depend on who compresses, controls and passes back most effectively.

Tip: The boat/team that identifies the control focus first, gains the initiative

The winning team now attempt to consolidate their position. For example, by stretching the race out so that it is harder for boats to change their race position.

In order to explain the "stretch" part of this process more clearly, let us now suppose that this successful manoeuvre

Diagram 1.6: STRETCH



A, in 2nd, tries to extend the gap (F). B helps by avoiding getting in the way, in this case, by gybing off

Then B tacks twice at the leeward mark to cover X. A is in clean air and can go fast

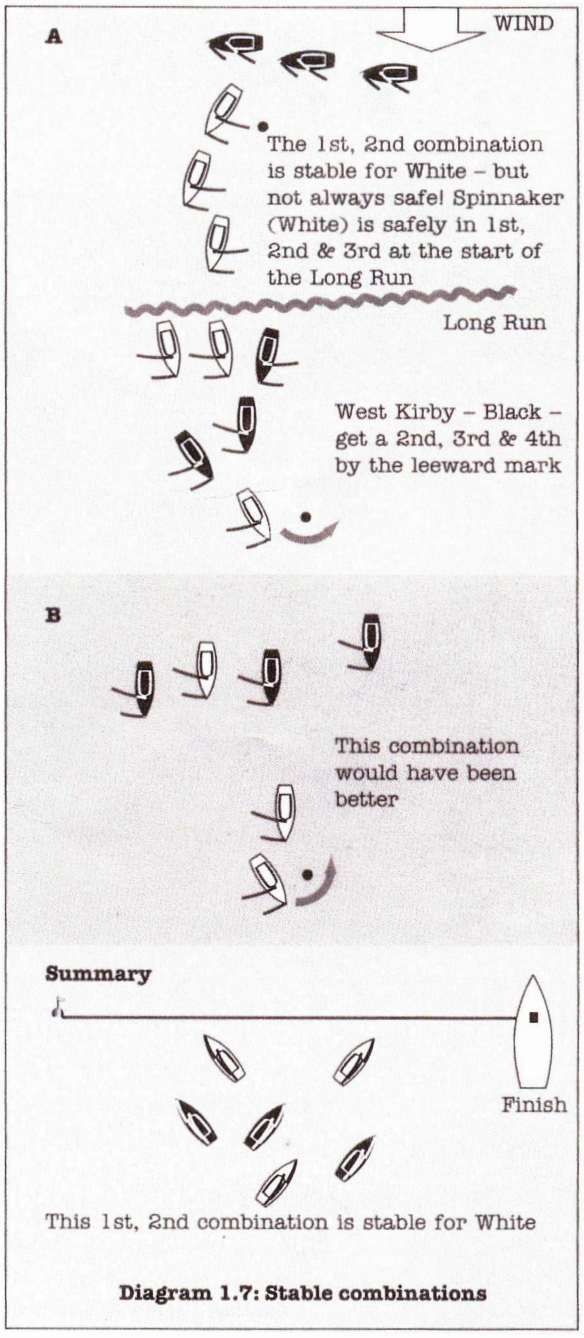


Diagram 1.7: Stable combinations

(exactly which manoeuvre it is is unimportant at the moment, the principle is what counts) results in a winning 1st and 2nd combination for the white team. Their second boat (who initiated the successful passback) is now very close to the enemy boat behind. This means they are at risk from this boat in terms of its getting past, perhaps by getting an overlap at a mark or doing a better tack. The 2nd boat (A) therefore decides to **make** the situation **less risky**. It sails fast and **stretches** out the race so there is as big **a gap** as possible where the race focus lies, which in this example is between A and X see Diagram 1.6.

Before I understood this concept our team (from the Spinnaker Club) were leading a Wilson Trophy race with a 1, 2, 3 combination. We went onto a run in this supposedly